The Milky Way

Dairy milk has been on somewhat of a roller-coaster ride in the past few decades. Once considered a premium source of calcium, good for the bones, milk became persona non grata once the surround sound around lactose intolerance and gut health started picking up in intensity—especially from the vegan community. According to a study in the *American Journal of Nutrition*, about 66 per cent of the population in South India is said to be lactose-intolerant, and about 27.4 per cent in the North. However, if you are among those who do not have lactose intolerance, a glass of milk in your daily diet would hardly be amiss. "Milk is even better than lentils, which are a second-class protein," says Rasika Parab, a nutritionist with the Fortis Group in Mumbai. "Milk is a complete protein. For vegetarians, it can provide essential protein important not only for daily functioning but also when one is recovering from illness. We often give some milk to our patients during their recovery period in the hospital." Only in two cases is milk to be avoided—when a person is lactose intolerant or has an upset stomach. And it is always better to get a doctor to diagnose whether a patient is lactose sensitive or not before replacing it with the more fashionable nut and soy milks.

In fact, nutritionists warn against eliminating any one food group from a diet. Or following a diet everyone on social media is into. "There are so many misconceptions about dieting," says Dr Leena N. Sreedhar, HoD and consultant obstetrics & gynaecology, at Manipal Hospitals in Dwarka, Delhi. "It has become fashionable to cut out entire food groups or to eat a lot of fat without understanding your body's requirements. This is harmful to health and counterproductive for weight loss as well."

What's Wrong to Eat

Quite simply, sugar, hydrogenated oil and excess salt. According to the seminal ICMR-INDIAB study conducted between 2008 and 2010, India's per capita consumption of added sugar rose from 22 gm a day in 2000 to more than double (55.3 gm) in 2010, and fat consumption from 21.2 gm per day in 2000 to 54 gm a decade later. The measure of hydrogenated fat, which is strongly linked with liver and heart disease, also shot up from 1.6 gm to 2.8 gm a day in the same period. We also consume 8 gm of salt a day, far more than the World Health Organization (WHO)-recommended 5 gm, as a recent ICMR survey reveals. Together, rising sugar, fat and salt levels in our diets have precipitated diseases ranging from cancer to infertility, hypertension to kidney failure.

A recent study in *BMC Medicine* examining the role of free sugars in heart health found that a mere 5 per cent increase in free sugars was linked to a 6 per cent higher risk of heart disease and a 10 per cent higher risk of stroke. "We used to consume sugars that came from whole grains or fruit or vegetable. Fats came from nuts, some vegetables, milk products and seeds. Added sugars and

A FEW FAQs

WHAT IS THE GLYCAEMIC INDEX?

Glycaemic Index (GI) is a way of ranking carb-containing foods on how slowly or quickly they get digested and increase glucose levels in the blood over a period of time, say, 2 hours. It uses glucose or white bread—which has a GI score of 100—as a reference food. Foods with low GI release sugar slowly into the blood, which helps with insulin sensitivity and cuts hunger pangs.

WHAT ARE CALORIES?

They are a measure of how much energy a food item gives you. Reducing calories in the diet forces body to burn stored energy (fat). However, experts warn against drastic reduction in calories as the body needs a certain amount of vitamins, minerals, proteins per day to function. Restricting calories can also slow down your metabolism to conserve energy. Professional guidance must be taken to determine how many calories to cut.

WEIGHT LOSS OR GOOD HEALTH?

While some amount of calorie restriction is advised to reduce previously-stored fats, most nutritionists recommend investing in good health. You can accomplish this by eating a balanced diet of complex carbs, proteins, fats and essential vitamins and minerals. Homecooked food, with the right amounts of micronutrients and calorie counts, can ensure both weight loss and good health.



Food Styling by SAGAR BAJAJ